

Nikki Kode

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Education

Carnegie Mellon University

Masters of Human-Computer Interaction

GPA: 3.86/4.00

Pittsburgh, PA

Expected Aug 2026

Relevant Coursework: User-Centered Research & Evaluation (05-610), Human-AI Interaction (05-318), AI Tools for Software Development (17-616), Machine Learning & Sensing for Healthcare (17-720), Interaction Design Fundamentals (05-660), Interactive Data Science (05-839), The AI Augmented Designer (05-899)

Bachelor of Computer Science and Arts (concentration in Music Technology)

May 2025

GPA: 3.63/4.00, University Honors

Skills

Research Methods: Usability studies, contextual inquiry, semi-structured interviews, survey design, thematic analysis, IRB protocol | **Languages:** Intermediate Spanish

Tools & Tech: Figma, Streamlit, Altair, Python, HTML, CSS, JavaScript, Otter.ai, Unity, Adobe Suite

Project Experience

Master's Capstone | XR Interaction Design Paradigms for ARM Holdings

Jan-Aug 2026

- Leading IRB-approved mixed-methods research with 70+ participants across two expert populations (tattoo artists and UX designers) using semi-structured interviews and participatory design techniques (e.g., body-mapping on a mannequin arm) to surface principles for on-skin XR interface design
- Designing and executing evaluative studies with a VR prototype to validate design principles with a general population, informing a research paper intended for publication
- Managing a 5-person cross-functional team in direct collaboration with ARM Holdings, coordinating research timelines, IRB protocols, and deliverables across the full study arc

TuneSense | Interactive Data Science Course Project

Mar-May 2026

- Designed and built an interactive music recommendation dashboard (Streamlit, Altair, Python) integrating Spotify Tracks and Billboard Hot 100 datasets, requiring substantial preprocessing to reconcile inconsistent data structures
- Implemented a user-controlled similarity scoring model with real-time feedback loops, allowing users to iteratively refine recommendations by approving or rejecting suggestions, demonstrating how transparency and explainability can improve trust in ML-driven systems
- Built an insights page visualizing each user's derived taste profile through summary statistics and interactive charts, surfacing patterns across audio features like energy, danceability, and valence

The Lodown — Local News Discovery | Course Project

Feb-May 2026

- Conducted field research at a local journalism event, interviewing community members, journalists, and photojournalists to understand barriers to local news consumption, surfacing multiple key insights
- Pivoted initial product direction based on research findings, shifting from a national-to-local redirect tool to a personalized local news feed allowing users to follow specific outlets, authors, and hyperlocal topics
- Built a website and browser extension (Pittsburgh pilot) implementing the revised concept, then conducted validation interviews with journalists to assess utility and refine the design

Steadigo | Interaction Design Fundamentals Course Project

Oct-Dec 2025

- Conducted persona-driven needfinding and competitive research to define safety and usability requirements for a semi-autonomous scooter designed for a child user with specific physical and cognitive constraints
- Built two rounds of physical and digital prototypes (paper → Figma), conducting usability testing each round to drive iteration — e.g., repositioning controls based on observed confusion between system and driving functions
- Delivered a multi-surface design system including a child-facing scooter dashboard & a parental companion app, with each design decision explicitly grounded in IxD principles (Fitts's Law, Hick's Law, proximity, error prevention)

Work Experience

Carnegie Mellon University, Pittsburgh, PA

Grader | Designing Human-Centered Software

Aug 2024– May 2025

- Evaluated student coursework including homework & group projects to support student understanding

Student Researcher | Robot Feedback Style to Optimize Human Exercise

May-Aug 2024

- Supported two PhD researchers in conducting participant sessions, managing equipment setup and transportation, and recording observational and survey data
- Contributed to a published study on robot feedback styles and their effect on human exercise performance